REP-014 · UI and UX polish: what feels unfinished, and a plan for the whole game

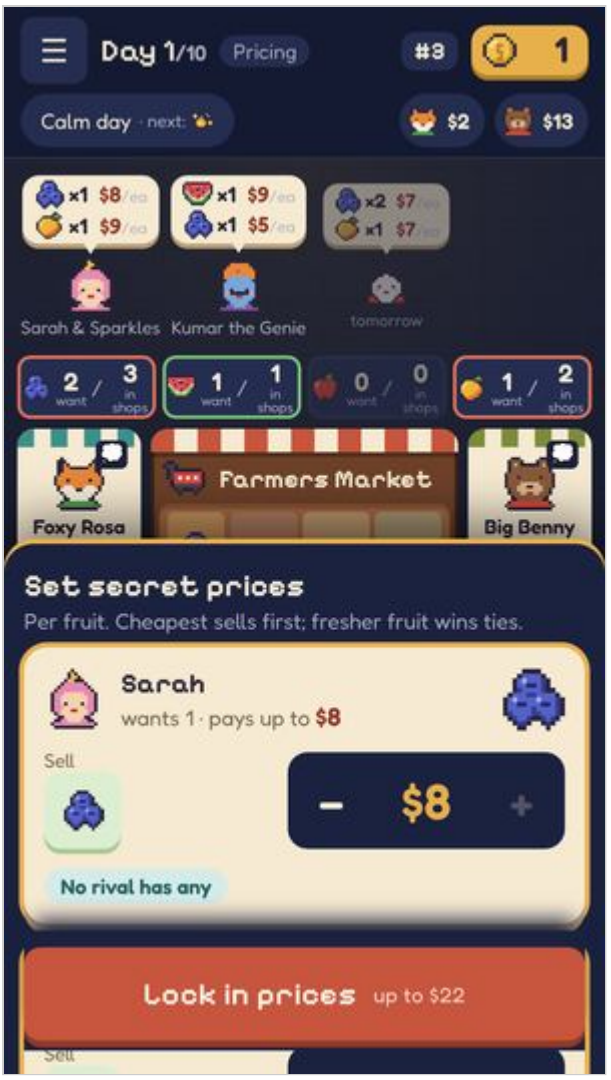
Game	Fruit Market
Report date	2026-10-26 23:06 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Owner input	"the look and feel of the game doesnt feel polished" and "the whole UI ... propose changes on the whole UI UX"
Build reviewed	1.1.1 candidate (`main @ 83de99b`), phone sizes 360×640 and 390×844
Type	Review and proposal. **No game changes were made.**
Approval status	DEC-020, PLAN-007 and PLAN-008 **awaiting approval**

1 · What I looked at

Every main screen at two common phone sizes: home, trait pick, buying, pricing, sales reveal, evening upgrades, results, trophies, online lobby and new game. The same checks the browser tests use: whether anything is cut off, overlaps or wastes space.


Day 1/10
Buying
#3
1
Calm day · next:
$10
$13
×1 $8
×1 $9
Sarah & Sparkles
walk-in
1+ / 3 want / in shops
? / 1 want / in shops
? / 0 want / in shops
1+ / 0 want / in shops
Foxy Rosa
Haggler
10
Farmers Market
Big Benny
Charmer
13
spoils
fresh
You
YOU
Big Basket
4/8
4/5
1
Your move
Tap a fruit in the market · 4/5 bought
Done buying


Day 1/10
Sales
+$8
#1
23
Calm day · next:
$11
$13
×2 $7
×1 $7
Sarah & Sparkles
Kumar the Genie
tomorrow
Foxy Rosa
Haggler
11
SHOWDOWN 1/3
cheapest sells first
Sarah & Sparkles
×1
pays up to $8 each
"Lovely!"
You
offers 1
SOLD
$8
No rivals! 1 blueberry sold at full price.
Big Benny
Charmer
13
You
YOU
Big Basket
1/8
23
Free Fruit
Skip
Selling... tap to speed up





2 · Why it doesn't feel polished: four causes

A. Things that look broken (defects, easy to fix)

1. **Sales reveal:** on shorter phones the explanation is cut off at the bottom ("...sold at full price" disappears behind the bar), and the card covers your own stall.
2. **The "+$8" money pop** flies off the top of the screen.
3. **Grammar:** "**You offers** 1" on the reveal card.
4. **Pricing panel:** the "Lock in prices" button floats over the next customer's card, which shows underneath it.
5. **Evening upgrades:** the Build buttons sit at different heights; card text is long and uneven.
6. **Trait picker:** the title wraps awkwardly and the panel covers your stall.
7. **Mixed icon styles:** emoji (🃏 favour count, ⏩ Skip, 💭, 📊, 🔒, 🧑/🤖) beside the pixel art.
8. **Placeholders that look unfinished:** the grey "walk-in" and "tomorrow" ghosts and the dashed "?" bubble.

9. **Trophies:** achievements have no icons, and locked and unlocked look the same (all grey text).

B. Too much on screen at once (layout)

- Before the table you see: the top bar, a second row (event, rival cash), customers, and a 4-box demand strip ("1+ want / 3 in shops"). That's four bands of small information.
- **Numbers shown twice:** your cash (top right and your stall) and rivals' cash (top chips and their stalls).
- **Rival stalls** take about 40% of the width to show mostly "0" rows, which squeezes the farmers market and makes its price labels ($1 $2 $3) tiny.
- **Your stall** is a big grid of empty pastel boxes with tiny "−$2" labels. Hard to read at a glance.

C. No single focus per moment Every phase shows the whole table at the same size. When you're pricing, the customers matter most; when you're buying, the market does. Right now nothing steps forward, so your eye has nowhere to land.

D. The visual system isn't consistent

- Two fonts are used without a clear rule: the pixel font appears in titles, numbers and small labels alike.
- Cards come in several styles: cream paper, navy chips, outlined boxes.
- Colours carry meaning (red outline, green outline, teal), but it isn't explained or applied consistently.
- Feedback and motion are uneven: some actions animate, others just switch.



3 · Proposal: three phases, smallest risk first

Phase 1 · Fix what looks broken (PLAN-007, build now, low risk)

All nine items in **A**, presentation only:

- the reveal card fits every phone and stops covering your stall
- the money pop stays on screen
- the grammar and other copy are corrected
- the pricing button sits in a solid footer
- upgrade cards are aligned and their text shortened
- the trait picker fits
- the remaining emoji become pixel icons (backlog B-33)
- the walk-in and tomorrow placeholders get proper art
- trophies get icons and a clear locked look

Ships with the Patches rename as **1.1.2**.

Phase 2 · Calm the table (PLAN-008 mockups first, then a build plan)

- **One compact top bar:** menu · day · phase · today's event icon · your cash and rank. Rivals' cash appears only on their stalls.
- **Slim rival stalls:** face, name, cash, and only the fruit they actually hold. This frees width so the farmers market and its prices get bigger.
- **Plain-language demand:** replace "1+ want / 3 in shops" with icons and words on the customer bubbles, for example "2 shops selling: price war".
- **Your stall:** show your fruit as items with "nights left", not a grid of empty boxes.
- **One focus per phase:** buying enlarges the market; pricing brings customers forward and dims the rest; the reveal gets the full stage; the evening shows only the upgrades.

Phase 3 · Make it feel finished (after Phase 2 is approved)

- **A small design system:** one type scale (pixel font for titles and big numbers only), one card style, spacing on a fixed grid, and colour roles (green good, red risk, gold money, teal info).
- **Motion and feedback:** phase transitions, a press effect on every button, and the **chalkboard reveal** from REP-010 (price boards flip). The reveal waits for the playtest result, because it's pillar 2.
- **Sound paired with the key moments** (backlog B-34), plus the harbour-market identity (DEC-017) on the home screen: a harbour backdrop, crates, chalkboards.

4 · Order of work (recommended)

1. **Now:** publish 1.1.1 and run the first playtest (DEC-016) on the *current* look. That gives a baseline, so we can show whether the new UI really makes the game clearer.
2. **Now, in parallel:** build Phase 1 (PLAN-007). Low risk; goes out as 1.1.2.
3. **Then:** PLAN-008, interactive mockups of the buy, price, reveal and evening screens plus home, as a page you can open on your phone, with two options where there's a real choice (for example, the rival stalls). **No game code.** You pick.
4. **Then:** a build plan for the chosen design (Phases 2 and 3), released as **1.2.0**, followed by a second playtest compared with the baseline.

5 · PLAN-007 acceptance (Phase 1)

- P1. Every item in **A** has before-and-after screenshots at 360×640 and 390×844.
- P2. Nothing is cut off or overlapping, and nothing scrolls sideways, on those sizes (automated check on each phase screen).
- P3. The visual-diff tool shows changes only on the screens being fixed.
- P4. The speed budget still passes (no long tasks over 200 ms; page size within budget).
- P5. `verify:full` is green; no rule, save or server changes.

PLAN-008 acceptance (mockups): an interactive page you can open on your phone, covering 5 screens, with clear options where a choice is needed, and every idea mapped to a problem above. No game code.

6 · Costs and risks

- RM0. No new tools or services.
- **Risk:** Phase 2 changes how the table is laid out, which could confuse returning players. Mitigation: mockups first, then the second playtest.
- **Risk:** polish can expand forever. Mitigation: each phase has a fixed list and its own approval.

7 · Questions for you (max 3)

1. **What bothers you most?**

   - (a) cluttered screens
   - (b) things that look broken
   - (c) it lacks animation or "feel"
   - (d) the art style itself

   (This sets the Phase 2–3 priorities. If it's (d), that's a bigger art decision.)

2. **Is there a game whose look you'd call "polished"?** A name or a screenshot helps me aim the mockups.

3. **Approve PLAN-007 (Phase 1 fixes) and PLAN-008 (mockups)?**

8 · Decisions

ID	Question	Recommendation	Status
DEC-020	How to polish the UI and UX	Three phases; fix defects first; mockups before any layout change; a playtest before and after	Awaiting approval
PLAN-007	Phase 1: fix what looks broken	Build now; ship in 1.1.2	Awaiting approval
PLAN-008	Interactive mockups for Phases 2–3	Design only, no game code	Awaiting approval